

Turkey Pipián Without the Imports

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CASAR 280S — Food Journal, Topic 2: Pre-Columbian Cuisine

When I actually sat down to plan a pre-1492 meal, I realized almost nothing I think of as "Mexican food" would qualify. Onion, garlic, cilantro, lime, chicken, pork, cheese — all of that came after contact. So the assignment ended up being less about adding ingredients and more about taking things away until only what was actually there was left. I picked central Mexico and built the meal around turkey (*Meleagris gallopavo*) in a green sauce thickened with ground squash seeds — basically a pipián, which is where mole comes from.

Everything in the dish is native to Mesoamerica and shows up in the archaeological record well before Europeans arrived. Maize (*Zea mays*) was domesticated from wild teosinte in the highlands of central Mexico — the earliest cobs date back around 6,300 years (Piperno and Flannery 2001:2101) — and that's what becomes the tortillas. Squash (*Cucurbita pepo*) is even older, one of the first plants ever domesticated in the Americas, going back roughly ten thousand years (Smith 1997:932). I didn't use the flesh of the squash, though — I used the toasted, ground seeds as the base of the sauce, which is how a kitchen without animal fat or oil got any richness (Coe 1994). Common beans (*Phaseolus vulgaris*) round out the maize-beans-squash combination that basically fed the whole region. I added tomatillo (*Physalis philadelphica*) and green chili (*Capsicum annuum*) to the sauce, avocado (*Persea americana*) on the side, and epazote (*Dysphania ambrosioides*) as the herb.

The turkey isn't just there for protein, either. It was one of the only animals actually domesticated in Mesoamerica, so having it in the dish is what makes this a full meal instead of just a vegetable

stew (Coe 1994). Where I'd normally grab chicken without thinking, I stuck with the bird that would have really been available.

Most of what I "substituted" was really just removed. A regular pipián verde recipe starts with onion and garlic sweated in oil, then cilantro and lime at the end — I cut all of that. Epazote takes the place of the cilantro, tomatillo provides the acidity that lime normally would, and the toasted seeds do the job fat usually does. Honestly, the dish doesn't lose that much. The parts that feel the most "authentically Mexican" — the toasted, nutty depth, the sour green sauce, the chili heat — were already here before any of the Old World ingredients showed up.

I didn't actually cook this one, but writing out the recipe still made the point of the assignment pretty clear: half the ingredients I'd normally reach for without thinking are imports, and once you take those out, what's left is a lot more distinctly Mesoamerican than I expected.

Works Cited

Coe, Sophie D. 1994. *America's First Cuisines*. Austin: University of Texas Press.

Piperno, Dolores R., and Kent V. Flannery. 2001. "The Earliest Archaeological Maize (*Zea mays* L.) from Highland Mexico: New Accelerator Mass Spectrometry Dates and Their Implications." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 98 (4): 2101–2103.

Smith, Bruce D. 1997. "The Initial Domestication of *Cucurbita pepo* in the Americas 10,000 Years Ago." *Science* 276 (5314): 932–934.

Appendix: Recipe — Turkey Pipián Verde (Pre-Columbian Mesoamerican)

Adapted by the author from the traditional Mexican pipián verde, with all post-1492 ingredients (onion, garlic, cilantro, lime, and cooking oil) removed and native substitutes used in their place.

Ingredients

- 1 turkey (*Meleagris gallopavo*), portioned (about 2 lb)
- 1 cup hulled squash/pumpkin seeds — pepitas (*Cucurbita pepo*)
- 8 tomatillos (*Physalis philadelphica*), husked
- 2–3 green chilies (*Capsicum annuum*), to taste
- 2 sprigs epazote (*Dysphania ambrosioides*)
- Salt, to taste
- 1 avocado (*Persea americana*), sliced, to garnish
- 2 cups cooked common beans (*Phaseolus vulgaris*), as a side
- Maize (*Zea mays*) tortillas, to serve

Method

1. Simmer the turkey in salted water with one sprig of epazote until tender; reserve the broth.
2. Toast the squash seeds in a dry pan until they pop and color, then grind them to a paste.
3. Simmer the tomatillos and chilies until soft, then grind them with the second sprig of epazote.
4. Combine the ground seeds and the tomatillo-chili purée, loosen with the reserved turkey broth, and cook gently until thickened, stirring constantly so the seed paste does not break.
5. Return the turkey to the sauce to warm through. Serve with beans, tortillas, and sliced avocado.